

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a newspaper article about calculators in school:

Calculators in schools to be banned!

By 2014, the use of calculators will be banned in primary school exams in England and severely restricted in lessons because children have become 'dependent' on them. Studies have shown that because current rules allow schools to introduce calculators freely from the age of seven, 98% of 10-year-olds in England rely on calculators in Maths lessons – far higher than the global average of 46%.

Schools will have to avoid introducing calculators until the final year of primary school, when most children are 10 years old. Calculators will also be banned in national tests for 11-year-olds. The government hopes that this will end the habit of 'simply reaching for the calculator' to work out basic sums (such as 900 minus 452). According to reports, students in Singapore, Hong Kong and Massachusetts, where calculators are already banned in Maths classes in primary schools, currently outperform pupils in England in Maths at the ages of 10 and 14.

'All young children should be confident with methods of addition, subtraction, multiplication and division before they pick up the calculator to work out more complex sums. By banning calculators in Maths tests, we will reduce the dependency on them in the classroom for the most basic sums. Children will have a solid grounding in the basics so they can grow up to be comfortable with the Maths they will need in their adult lives,' says an English official.

Your group has to prepare for a debate with the motion *Calculators should NOT be banned in primary schools*. Discuss with your group what to include in this debate. You may want to talk about:

- advantages of using calculators in primary schools
- problems of using calculators in primary schools
- whether or not you agree that calculators should be banned in primary schools
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like Maths classes?
2. Do you use a calculator for simple maths?
3. Are you able to do maths without a calculator?
4. Is it okay if primary school students use calculators at home?
5. Does having maths skills help you in life in general?
6. Do you think people who can do maths without a calculator are smarter than those who cannot?
7. Are schools in Hong Kong putting too much emphasis on mental arithmetic?
8. Do you think the dependency on calculators is a cause of poor maths results?